During the fierce second wave of Covid-19 in 2021, Ananya Lohani, 23, decided to download a dating app in search of both companionship and an emotional anchor. It took the Pune-based research intern two weeks to find what she thought was a compatible match. Over the next nine months, the couple chatted daily, went on virtual dates and shared details of their lives and dreams. In 2022, Lohani was ready to meet her online boyfriend in person. But he kept dilly-dallying. "We'd fix a date and he would cancel it at the last minute. This kept happening for two weeks. Fed up, I told him I saw no future with him," says Lohani.

However, instead of accepting her decision, her online suitor kept pursuing her. "I had to change my number, email ID and social media accounts, as he would keep messaging me. Most were apologies, but some were angry drunken rants, even threats. It was terrifying." The experience left her so shaken that she went off dating. "What was really frightening," recalls Lohani, "was to discover that someone you trusted could have such a different side to them."

With the Covid lockdown limiting options to find or meet partners offline, many like Lohani had turned to dating apps—to have fun, make new friends, hook up digitally or find a potential long-term partner. According to research firm Sensor Tower, the global use of Tinder, Bumble and Hinge—three popular dating apps—collectively grew by 17 per cent between January 2019 and January 2022. A 2021 survey by Bumble, which has over 4.5 million users in India, found that as many as 42 per cent began using the app for the first time that year. The survey also found that 65 per cent of its Indian users were looking forward to meeting their matches in person in 2022. "There has been growing acceptance and popularity of meeting partners on dating apps. Many parents, too, approve of it. But little has been done to help users cope with the negative impact of unhealthy relationships," says Deekshaa Athwani, a Mumbai-based clinical psychologist.

Experts say the digital dating culture of unlimited swipes (liking or rejecting probable matches), disappearance after flawless dates and online cheating has left many users with loss of confidence, swipe (or dating app) fatigue and emotional burnout. A global survey of Hinge users found that 61 per cent of them were overwhelmed by modern dating, while an April 2022 US study showed four in five adults experiencing emotional fatigue from online dating. In India, a 2022 survey by dating app Quack Quack found nearly a third of its users feeling frustrated with the need to be desirable and 41 per cent feeling dejected about not finding a match within the first week of being on the app.

For some who have taken their relationship offline, there have also been different, darker consequences. Besides the horror story currently playing out endlessly on TV channels, of the murder of 26-year-old Shraddha Walkar, cases of rape, extortion and stalking among relationships that started on dating apps have been appearing regularly in news reports over the past year. Can you, then, really ever trust someone you meet online? "Tradition-

THE LINGO OF TOXIC DATING

A new vocabulary of dysfunctional digital behaviour

NEGGING



Short for negative feedback, it is when one hides criticism under compliments. 'You're not as dumb as you look', for example

BREADCRUMBING



When a potential partner leaves a trail of expectations but never fulfils them—from constantly postponing a date to not committing to a long-term relationship

FLEABAGGING



Inspired by the dark sitcom *Fleabag*, this is the cycle of falling in and out of love with a person who leaves you emotionally drained

ORBITING



Exhibited by people who put you through a cycle of rejections and acceptance

CUSHIONING



Happens when someone is entertaining other potential romantic options while still being in a committed relationship

ROACHING



Hiding the fact that you're seeing others from the person you're dating

POCKETING



Where a partner hides the other from the public, keeping the relationship under wraps